

Saul Before Paul

A 50-minute teaching script for Acts 7:54-9:19, Galatians 1:11-24, and Philippians 3:4-11

BIG IDEA Saul's religious credentials and zeal made him certain he was serving God, even while he opposed Christ and attacked Christ's church. By grace, Jesus confronted him, overturned his confidence, and brought him into the church he tried to destroy.

Before class, write on the board: What happens when sincere religious certainty is confronted by the risen Christ?

0:00-3:00 | Welcome and opening prayer

Good morning. Last week we began learning how to read Paul's letters by moving from the Whole Bible, to the Whole Letter, and then to the Passage. Before we begin reading those letters, however, we need to meet the man who wrote them. Today Acts will tell us what happened to Saul, and Galatians and Philippians will show us how Paul later understood what happened.

Let's pray. Father, send your Holy Spirit to guide us and teach us. Help us hear your Word with humility. Show us where confidence in ourselves, our traditions, or our religious accomplishments may keep us from hearing Christ. Give us grace to receive those whom Christ receives. In Jesus' name, amen.

3:00-6:00 | Frame the lesson

Here is our opening question: Can someone be sincere, informed, morally serious, and zealous for God - and still be badly wrong about what God is doing?

Allow only one or two quick responses. Tell the class the passages will answer the question.

Saul was not an irreligious thug. He was educated, disciplined, morally serious, and zealous. He believed he was defending God. Yet his religious certainty had made him deaf to God's truth and violent toward God's people. Instead of destroying him, the risen Jesus confronted, humbled, and claimed him by grace.

6:00-11:00 | Read Acts 7:54-8:4

Ask one reader to read Acts 7:54-8:4 while everyone follows in a Bible or Bible app. Before the reading, ask everyone to notice what Stephen sees, what the council refuses to hear, how Saul is introduced, and what happens after Stephen dies.

11:00-19:00 | Stephen, the council, and Saul

Luke gives us a striking contrast. Stephen is filled with the Spirit and sees clearly. The council is religiously certain but refuses to hear. Stephen speaks about the heavenly court. The earthly court dissolves into a violent mob.

They cover their ears because they believe Stephen is speaking blasphemy. Then, with one shared purpose, they rush him and drag him outside the city. Stephen has appealed to heaven, but the earthly court is no longer acting like a court.

F. F. Bruce describes Stephen as condemned by an earthly court but appealing to a heavenly court, where Jesus stands as his advocate. That is a compelling interpretation of why Stephen sees Jesus standing at God's right hand. At the very least, heaven's verdict about Stephen is completely different from the mob's verdict.

Then Luke introduces a young man named Saul. Saul is not merely a coat-check attendant standing outside the action. Acts 8:1 says he approved of Stephen's killing. Later, in Acts 22, Paul admits that he stood there approving and guarding the clothes of those who killed Stephen. Luke does not tell us what Saul felt while Stephen died. He tells us what Saul did next.

Stephen's final words matter. He prayed, 'Lord, do not hold this sin against them.' Saul was present. He approved the killing and assisted those carrying it out. Stephen's prayer therefore included Saul, even though Scripture never says that Stephen's prayer caused Saul's conversion.

SAY CLEARLY Before Saul knew he needed grace, Stephen was praying for grace to be shown to his persecutors - including Saul.

Stephen's death may appear to be a terrible waste, but evil could not silence his witness or stop Christ's mission. Acts 8:4 gives us the reversal: Saul tried to scatter the church, but the scattered church spread the gospel.

Ask: What warning does this give churches about religious certainty that refuses to listen? Allow two or three responses.

19:00-21:00 | Summarize Acts 8

We will not read the remainder of Acts 8 aloud. Philip preaches in Samaria and then shares the gospel with an Ethiopian official. Persecution caused real suffering, but it could not stop Christ's mission. Before Saul became a missionary, ordinary scattered Christians were already carrying the gospel beyond Jerusalem.

21:00-26:00 | Read Acts 9:1-19

Before the reading, ask everyone to notice four things: Who takes the initiative? What does Saul intend to do? What can Saul do after meeting Jesus? What does Jesus ask Ananias to do?

26:00-31:00 | Christ confronts Saul

Saul begins this journey with authority from the high priest. He plans to enter Damascus as a captor, arrest followers of Jesus, and drag them back to Jerusalem. But Saul does not complete the mission. Christ interrupts it.

The man who believed he could see more clearly than the followers of Jesus is struck blind. The powerful man becomes helpless. Saul intended to enter Damascus carrying prisoners. Instead, he enters blind and led by the hand.

Then Jesus asks, 'Saul, Saul, why do you persecute me?' Saul thought he was attacking a dangerous religious movement. Jesus reveals that attacking Christ's people means attacking Christ himself. Saul's first revelation about Jesus therefore includes a revelation about the church: Christ identifies himself with his suffering people.

Saul has attacked Jesus himself and has every reason to expect judgment. Judgment does come: Christ stops him, blinds him, and humbles him. But this is judgment enveloped in mercy. Instead of destroying his enemy, Jesus claims him.

31:00-36:00 | Ananias receives Saul

Now consider Ananias. His response is almost, 'Really, Lord? You want me to do what?' But his fear is not imaginary or irrational. He has heard accurate reports about Saul. Saul has authority to arrest people like Ananias.

God does not tell Ananias, 'Don't worry; Saul is harmless.' God tells him, 'Go. This man is my chosen instrument.' Ananias must trust that Jesus knows Saul better than Saul's reputation does and that Christ's grace can create a genuine brother out of the church's enemy.

Ananias goes into the house, places his hands upon the man who came to arrest him, and says, 'Brother Saul.' That may be one of the most gospel-shaped greetings in Acts.

CORPORATE EMPHASIS Jesus did not merely reconcile Saul to himself. Jesus sent a member of the persecuted church to receive the persecutor as a brother.

Ask: What did obedience require Ananias to believe about Jesus - and about Saul? Allow several responses.

36:00-40:00 | Galatians: Who took the initiative?

Read Galatians 1:11-16 and 22-24. Ask the class to notice the verbs describing what God did.

Paul says God set him apart, called him by grace, revealed his Son, and commissioned him to preach. Paul's gospel was not an idea he invented, and its authority did not rest on where he studied or which human teacher trained him. Its ultimate source and authority were Jesus Christ.

John Stott makes a helpful distinction. Saul's encounter with Christ was sudden, but God's work was not. The light was sudden to Saul, but Galatians says God had set him apart before Saul recognized what God was doing.

When Paul later tells the story in Acts 26, Jesus says, 'It is hard for you to kick against the goads.' A goad directed an animal; kicking it only caused further pain. The basic point is that Saul had been resisting God and could not win. Scripture never identifies the particular goads, so we should not invent a hidden psychological biography for Saul.

TEACHING LINE Saul's conversion was sudden enough to knock him to the ground, but it was not sudden to God.

40:00-44:00 | Philippians: What changed?

Read Philippians 3:4-9, emphasizing verse 7. Ask the class to identify Saul's former grounds for confidence.

Paul lists heritage, religious identity, affiliation, zeal, law-keeping, and reputation. These were not all inherently wicked. The problem was that Saul used them as grounds for righteousness, confidence, and superiority.

Then comes the hinge: 'But whatever were gains to me I now consider loss for the sake of Christ.' Jesus did not merely give Saul new information. Jesus overturned Saul's entire accounting system. What Saul once counted as gain became loss, and knowing Christ became his surpassing treasure.

SYNTHESIS Acts shows Christ stopping Saul. Galatians shows God calling Saul by grace. Philippians shows grace changing what Saul valued.

44:00-48:00 | The Gospel Then and Now

Now bring the question to the church. What good religious things can churches turn into grounds for confidence, superiority, or resistance to Christ?

If needed, prompt with: denominational heritage, correct doctrine, moral reputation, political identity, worship traditions, biblical knowledge, years of service, or connection to respected teachers.

The gospel answer is not that doctrine, tradition, education, or zeal are bad. The gospel tells us that none of them can replace Christ or become the basis for our righteousness and superiority.

Ask: How can a church distinguish between valuing a good gift and placing its confidence in that gift?

A gospel-shaped church listens humbly, submits its traditions and credentials to Christ, and - like Ananias - receives those whom Christ has received.

48:00-50:00 | Summary, homework, and prayer

Saul was religiously certain, but he was wrong about Jesus and violent toward Jesus' church. Christ confronted him, showed him grace, overturned his values, and used Ananias to receive him as a brother. The gospel does not merely improve our religious resume. It gives us Christ as our righteousness and makes former enemies into one church.

Before next week, read Acts 9:1-31, Acts 13:1-12, and Romans 15:14-33. Notice who calls and sends Paul, what mission he receives, and how he understands his responsibility to churches and people who have not heard the gospel.

Let's pray. Lord Jesus, thank you for showing mercy to your enemies and bringing us into your family by grace. Keep your church from trusting its credentials more than Christ. Give us the humility to listen, the courage to obey, and the grace to receive those whom you receive. Amen.

Optional material if discussion moves quickly

Compare Acts 9:4-6 with Acts 22:8-10. Andrew Purves's memorable formulation captures the two questions: 'Who are you, Lord?' and 'What are you up to?' In Acts 22 Paul explicitly asks, 'What shall I do, Lord?' The questions join knowing Christ with being summoned into Christ's mission.

Brief name note: Saul did not receive the name Paul at conversion. Saul was his Jewish name and Paul his Roman name; Acts 13:9 identifies both.